상황별 인사말: 언제, 누구에게, 어떻게 말해요?

A short guide to Korean greetings for work, holidays, meals, illness and goodbyes, with polite and casual forms for different listeners.

WHAT THIS IS FOR

By the end, you can find the right greeting in a list for a given situation, and change it to the right speech level for a senior or a close friend.

1 상황별 인사말 목록

1. **먼저 들어가 보겠습니다** (I'll head home first)
   Say it when you leave work while your boss or coworkers are still there.
   예: 과장님, 저 먼저 들어가 보겠습니다.
2. **수고하셨습니다** (thank you for your hard work)
   Say it to coworkers or people younger than you when a day's work or a task is finished. Some people feel it is rude to a boss or elder, so use 고생 많으셨습니다 for them.
   예: 민수 씨, 오늘 발표 준비하느라 수고하셨습니다.
3. **새해 복 많이 받으세요** (Happy New Year)
   Use it around 1 January and Seollal (Lunar New Year), especially to older people.
   예: 할아버지, 새해 복 많이 받으세요.
4. **즐거운 명절 보내세요** (have a happy holiday)
   Say it before Seollal or Chuseok, when people go home to their families.
   예: 다음 주가 추석이네요. 즐거운 명절 보내세요.
5. **생신 축하드립니다** (happy birthday (to an elder))
   생신 is the honorific word for 생일; use it for parents, grandparents or a boss.
   예: 어머님, 생신 축하드립니다.
6. **얼른 나으세요** (get well soon)
   Say it to someone who is sick or hurt.
   예: 다리 다치셨다면서요? 얼른 나으세요.
7. **그동안 감사했습니다** (thank you for everything)
   Say it on the last day, when you leave a job, class or group.
   예: 오늘이 마지막 수업이네요. 선생님, 그동안 감사했습니다.
8. **잘 먹겠습니다** (thank you for the meal)
   Say it before eating, especially when someone else pays or cooks.
   예: 와, 맛있겠다! 잘 먹겠습니다.
9. **들어가세요** (goodbye, take care)
   Use it to end a phone call or to say goodbye to someone older; it does not mean 'go inside'.
   예: 네, 알겠습니다. 그럼 들어가세요.

2 같은 인사, 다른 말투

Same situation, different listener. To a senior: 고생 많으셨습니다 / 새해 복 많이 받으세요 / 얼른 나으세요. To a close friend or someone younger: 수고했어 / 새해 복 많이 받아 / 얼른 나아. Honorific words change too: 생신 → 생일, 드리다 → 하다.

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3 문화 팁: 한국 인사 문화

Many Koreans avoid saying 수고하세요 to a boss, because it can sound like telling them to keep working. When you leave first, say 먼저 들어가 보겠습니다 instead.
'밥 먹었어요?' is often just a friendly hello, not an invitation to eat. A short answer like '네, 먹었어요' is enough.

This list shows greetings Koreans use every day, sorted by situation and by who you are talking to.

4 YOUR TURN

CHOOSE THE RIGHT GREETING
Read the situation, think about who the listener is, and pick or write the greeting that fits.

1. Choose the right greeting:
저녁 6시예요. 팀장님은 아직 일하고 계세요. 나는 지금 집에 가요.
(a) 팀장님, 수고하세요.
(b) 팀장님, 먼저 들어가 보겠습니다.

2. Write the greeting for each situation:
①설날 아침에 큰아버지께
②친구가 독감에 걸려서 학교에 못 왔어요. 친구에게 문자로
③3년 동안 다닌 회사를 그만두는 날, 동료들에게

3. Change the greeting for a close friend:
할머니, 생신 축하드립니다. → 지수야, ____.

4. Fill in the blank:
부장님이 오늘 저녁을 사 주셨어요. 먹기 전에 → 부장님, 잘 ____.

5. True or False:
①전화를 끊을 때 '들어가세요'는 'Please go inside.'라는 뜻이에요.
②'밥 먹었어요?'는 인사로 자주 써요.
③친한 친구에게는 '추석 잘 보내세요'보다 '추석 잘 보내'가 더 자연스러워요.

ANSWERS

1) (b) 팀장님, 먼저 들어가 보겠습니다.
2) ① 새해 복 많이 받으세요. ② 얼른 나아. (빨리 나아.) ③ 그동안 감사했습니다.
3) 생일 축하해
4) 먹겠습니다
5) ① False ② True ③ True

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